

an expert in the code. This enables you to find jobs at companies who use that software, as an in-house specialist, or as someone who maintains and modifies addons that the company uses. And if you thought that there was a slump in the amount of companies using OSS, think again. "There is definitely growth in demands for open source technology. Customers are looking for reliable, high-performing and agile technologies that can address their complex IT challenges, while allowing them to plan ahead for the future. This is where open source technology can help to meet these demands," said Andy Karandikar, Pre-sales & Services Head, Red Hat India, Red Hat India about the importance of open source technology in the industry today.

In order to structure our look at the industry for this article, we've broken it into various intersecting domains.

Desktop

One of the most traditional software markets, the open source connection here is GNU/Linux. In a recent discussion session following a presentation at Aalto University, Linus Torvalds, the creator of Linux, said – "I started Linux as a desktop operating system. And it's the only area where Linux hasn't completely taken over. That just annoys the hell out of me". Yes, it's true that the desktop market is ruled by Windows, but Linux is slowly and surely gaining traction with both consumers



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and enterprises alike. It certainly isn't this alien OS that it once was, thanks to Ubuntu and the likes. The career opportunity here is developing new apps and porting existing apps to Linux. Ubuntu, for example, has launched "Ubuntu App

Showdown" which asks developers over the world to develop apps for Ubuntu and has even declared prizes for the same. Most companies recruit seasoned developers as consultants on contractual basis for porting or developing new apps to Linux.

Mobile and embedded systems

Android, perhaps the most famous OSS project today, is one of the most prevalent OSes in smartphones. According to the latest figures about 900,000 Android phones are activated per day – that's about 28 million droids sold every month! 10 every second!

The primary career opportunity in this space is as an Android App Developer. Google Play, the newly-rebranded Android app store crossed 15 billion app downloads a few weeks back. According to one analyst, Google has paid out about \$320 million to developers until January 2012. What this means is that it's very lucrative for developers – most of them employed by companies to build apps, rather than individuals. Of course, there are also more places to sell the same apps, thanks to companies such as Amazon.

Another open source app development platform to look out for is HTML5. In fact it would be appropriate to call HTML 5 as "the next big thing" when it comes to development frameworks. According to a joint survey carried out by IDG and Appcelerator, 79 per cent of mobile developers report that they will integrate HTML5 in their apps this year. This figure is much higher than what many industry observers had anticipated in the fourth quarter of 2011. The biggest challenge that the developers face here is fragmentation and the fact that HTML5 is still a work in progress.

Next in line are embedded systems – the software and hardware that power our day-to-day appliances such as microwaves, refrigerators, washing machines and even toasters. Software front-runners in this space are Linux and Android. Android in particular is being used in a multitude of embedded devices right now. There are a quite a lot of job opportunities for working on the kernel and device drivers for such system, along with front-end development for touch-screen-based apps.

HERE ARE SOME OF THE MODELS FOR MAKING MONEY IN OPEN SOURCE

SUPPORT / CONSULTING SERVICES:

This is where you would give your software away for free, but charge for professional support. This is the Red Hat and Canonical (Ubuntu) model.

DUAL-LICENSING:

This is where you distribute your product as OSS, but also have special licensing for corporations. Of course, corporations could still choose to use your software in an Open Source manner, but then they would also have to agree to share any code for addons to your software that they develop in-house. This is why many large corporations who modify OSS products to suit themselves prefer to pay for dual-licensed products in the interest of security. Kendo UI adopts this model.

WIDGET FROSTING:

Usually employed by hardware vendors who go open source to get better drivers and cheaper interface tools designed by the community. Silicon Graphics employs this model.

ACCESSORISING:

Selling accessories – usually books and compatible hardware but you can also trivialise this to include T-shirts, coffee mugs, penguin dolls and so on. Canonical and Mustache.js work on this model.